

COACH WOO HAS EMPHASISED THE IMPORTANCE OF VERY HIGH LEVELS OF FITNESS, SAYING THAT IT WAS THE PILLAR ON WHICH OLYMPIC SUCCESS RESTED.

Photographs by SUBIR HALDER



ON TARGET:
(Clockwise from
top left)
Bombayla, Dola,
and Pranitha

Archery Championships in Leipzig. Along with Dola, this archer from Imphal has Woo's faith.

Pranitha is the surprise, unknown quantity of the team. Originally from Parvathagiri village of Warangal district in Andhra Pradesh, she is now with the Tata Archery Academy at Jamshedpur. She turned in a cool performance at the Kolkata trials, far better than her older teammates.

Her broken Hindi and smattering of English is sufficient for her to let all inquisitors know that while she is happy about getting a berth to Beijing, she is hardly overawed. Perhaps, the fact that she is not burdened with any expectation may actually help her compete freely. It is something that produces a rare smile from Woo.

But as the Games near, coach Woo frets too. His worry now is the fitness levels of the team. He explains, "In

archery, fitness matters a lot. Only if you are fit can skill and concentration come into play." Without the necessary strength and endurance, he says, "It is difficult to last the gruelling long sessions under the pressure of competition. It is very difficult to concentrate if you don't have the strength." He believes that fitness and concentration levels of the portly Champia are very high now. "He and Bombayla have improved over the last year," he says.

Woo was hired as coach by the Mittal's Champion's Trust (MCT). Initially he was working with Champia and Bombayla as the two are sponsored by the MCT. He started coaching Dola and Pranitha only after the final Olympic berths were confirmed at the end of the Kolkata trials in late June. With the short time at his disposal before the Games begin—not more than six weeks—Woo had looked

after the other two women as well. He has had to try to fix their rough patches while making sure their confidence levels remained intact. He was aware that Dola had excelled at the highest level but also realised she was not shooting at her best in 2008. "I am trying to guide her as much as I can in the little time that we have before the Olympics," he says.

Mukherjee insisted that the team was heading for Beijing in the right frame of mind. Dola and Champia had results from international events. Bombayla's improvement and Pranitha's promise, he believes, were the best signs. All they needed was the right atmosphere to concentrate on the competition ahead.

Once again he articulates the team's outlook on the 2008 Olympics, "We are going there to compete. To win. Not just to participate."